

Fieldstone Foundation

Community Development Grant Program

Application Guidelines - Fiscal Year 2026

Document Version: August 2026 | Effective for all applications submitted October 1 - December 31, 2026

1. PROGRAM OVERVIEW

The Fieldstone Foundation Community Development Grant Program supports community-based organizations and public institutions engaged in sustainable agriculture, food security, and culturally responsive education in underserved rural communities of North Carolina. Grants are awarded on a competitive basis to applicants demonstrating strong community partnerships, measurable outcomes, and a clear path to sustainability beyond the grant period.

2. ELIGIBILITY

Eligible applicants include 501(c)(3) nonprofit organizations, public universities and their extension programs, tribal organizations, and units of local government operating in North Carolina. Applicants must serve communities with documented socioeconomic disadvantage in agricultural access, land tenure, or food security.

3. GRANT PARAMETERS

Grant Ceiling: \$85,000 per award

Maximum Program Duration: 2 years

Indirect Cost Rate: Up to 15% of total direct costs

Narrative Page Limit: 15 pages (single-spaced, 11-point font, 1-inch margins)

Budget Format: Line-item budget with justification narrative

Matching Funds: Not required but favorably reviewed

4. APPLICATION COMPONENTS

A complete application must include:

- a) Grant Narrative (max 15 pages) addressing:
 - Executive Summary
 - Community Context (demographics, challenges, assets)
 - Program Design (activities, timeline, staffing)
 - Evaluation Plan (methods, metrics, reporting schedule)
 - Sustainability Plan (post-grant continuation strategy)
 - Budget Justification
- b) Line-Item Budget Spreadsheet
- c) Letters of Support (minimum 3 from community partners)

d) Organizational Capacity Statement (1 page)

e) Evaluation Rubric: All applicants must include a self-assessment rubric demonstrating how the proposed program addresses each of the Foundation's five priority areas (see Section 7).

f) Appendices as needed (soil data, curriculum samples, maps)

5. TIMELINE AND DEADLINES

Application Open: September 1, 2026

Optional Letter of Intent: September 15, 2026

Full Application Deadline: October 31, 2026 (5:00 PM ET)

Review Period: November 1 - December 15, 2026

Award Notifications: January 5, 2027

Grant Period Begins: February 1, 2027

Note: The maximum program duration is 2 years from the grant start date. Programs proposing longer timelines will not be considered. All program activities must be completed within the 2-year period, and a final evaluation report is due within 60 days of program completion.

6. BUDGET GUIDELINES

The maximum grant award is \$85,000. Indirect costs may not exceed 15% of total direct costs. The budget must be presented in a line-item format with the following columns: Line Item, Category, Description, Amount, and Notes.

All budget items must be justified in the narrative. Personnel costs should reflect actual time commitment to the proposed program. Equipment purchases over \$5,000 require additional justification.

The Foundation reserves the right to negotiate budget modifications prior to award execution.

7. EVALUATION CRITERIA

Applications will be reviewed and scored on the following criteria (100 points total):

1. Community Need and Context (20 points)

- Clear documentation of need
- Understanding of community assets and barriers

2. Program Design and Innovation (25 points)

- Clear and achievable program activities
- Culturally responsive approach
- Integration of community knowledge

3. Evaluation Plan (20 points)

- Measurable outcomes with clear metrics
- Appropriate data collection methods
- Evaluation rubric addressing Foundation priorities

4. Organizational Capacity (15 points)

- Staff qualifications and experience
- Community partnerships and trust
- Institutional support

5. Sustainability and Impact (20 points)

- Viable post-grant sustainability plan
- Potential for replication
- Long-term community benefit

8. REPORTING REQUIREMENTS

Grantees must submit:

- Mid-year progress report (6 months after start)
- Annual evaluation report (12 months)
- Final comprehensive report (within 60 days of program end)
- Financial accounting with receipts for expenditures over \$500

Reports should reference the evaluation rubric submitted with the application and document progress against stated metrics.

9. CONTACT INFORMATION

Program Officer: Dr. Amara Okafor

Email: a.okafor@fieldstone-fdn.org

Grants Office: grants@fieldstone-fdn.org

Phone: (919) 555-0147

Review Panel Chair: Richard Osei-Mensah

Email: r.oseimensah@fieldstone-fdn.org

Mailing Address:

Fieldstone Foundation

310 Heritage Drive, Suite 200

Durham, NC 27701